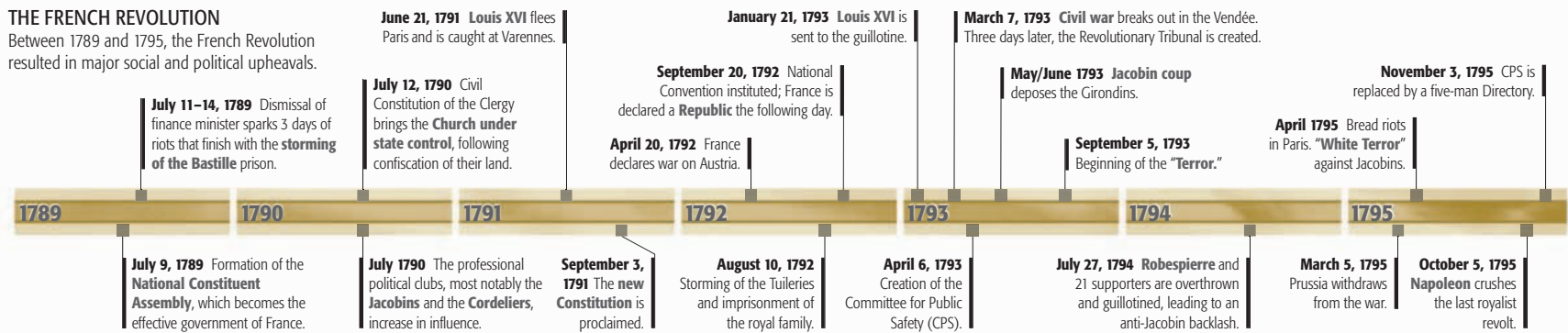


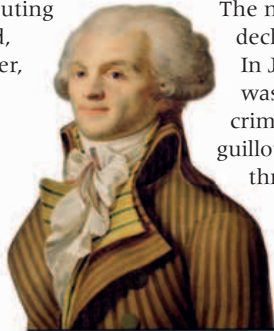
THE FRENCH REVOLUTION

Between 1789 and 1795, the French Revolution resulted in major social and political upheavals.



domestic problems. While saluting the revolution with one hand, the king plotted with the other, hoping that French defeat would restore his fortunes.

A series of military defeats brought panic to Paris. A Prussian manifesto that threatened the French people if any harm came to Louis inflamed the Parisian radicals, who stormed the Tuilleries on August 20, deposing the king. At the same time, a revolutionary Commune took control of the city and encouraged the massacre of 1,200 "counter-revolutionary" prisoners, provoking international horror. A third, more radical Assembly (the Convention) was elected and a crucial victory at the battle of Valmy on September 20 helped to restore national confidence.



"The Incorruptible"

Maximilien Robespierre, a radical politician, was the effective leader of France during the Reign of Terror.

The next day, the Convention declared France a Republic. In January 1793, the king was found guilty of "the crime of being a king" and guillotined, sending shockwaves through Europe.

Foreign invasion once more threatened the nation, and France became more militarized. It relied on conscription and revolutionary zeal for its citizen armies, fighting a series of revolutionary wars

that were bankrolled by loot from newly "liberated" countries. At the same time, a major counterrevolution, provoked by mass conscription, broke out in Brittany and the Vendée (western France). Atrocities became commonplace on both sides.

Execution of Marie Antoinette

When Queen Marie Antoinette was guillotined on October 16, 1793, few mourned. Deeply unpopular, she was found guilty of treason by the Revolutionary Tribunal.



IDEA

HUMAN RIGHTS

The French Revolution's most lasting legacy was its *Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen*, published on August 26, 1789. Inspired by the political writings of John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, this bold document stated that all "men are born and remain free and with equal rights," and that the duty of government was to preserve these "natural and inviolate rights... liberty, property, security and resistance to oppression" through a constitution, rooted in the rule of law. Although originally neglecting women's rights, its universal appeal made it the basis for the constitutions of many countries as well as the UN's *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*, published in 1948.

LA DÉCLARATION



"Virtue without which terror is deadly; terror without which virtue is impotent."

MAXIMILIEN ROBESPIERRE, FEBRUARY 5, 1794

Faced with mounting military and economic problems, the government founded the Revolutionary Tribunal, to provide instant justice, and the Committee for Public Safety (CPS), to centralize power. Meanwhile, increasing conflict within the Convention culminated with the expulsion of a faction known as the Girondins on June 2, and the rise to power of the Jacobins.

The Jacobins and the "Terror"

Under Robespierre's leadership, the Jacobins aimed to create a new "Republic of Virtue." "Citizen" became the common form of address, a new revolutionary calendar was introduced, towns were renamed, and the education system reformed.

On September 5, 1793, "terror" was made "the order of the day" and "war" declared on those suspected of counter-revolutionary sympathies, creating an oppressive climate of informers and instant justice. In 10 months, 20,000 "enemies of the revolution" were executed across France. A decisive military victory over Austria in June 1794 eased the pressure, but there was no letup in the daily flow of victims to the guillotine. Robespierre and his supporters were finally toppled by

fearful fellow deputies, and this was followed by an anti-Jacobin backlash (the "White Terror") and a return to more moderate policies. In 1795, the CPS was replaced by a five-man Directory. Royalist-radical tensions pulled France in both directions and two elections were annulled. In 1799, a coup d'état installed Napoleon Bonaparte (see pp.304–05) as leader—five years later, he became emperor of France.

AFTER

The success of the French Revolution, and its spirit of "liberty, equality, fraternity," helped to inspire wars of independence far beyond Europe.

IMPACT OVERSEAS

In 1791, **Toussaint l'Ouverture** led a successful **slave revolt** in the French colony of Saint-Domingue (Haiti). From 1808, **revolutionary nationalism** inspired the wars of independence against Spain in Latin America **318–19** >>>

LEGACY IN FRANCE

While the revolution failed in some ways, the legacy of popular insurrection established a radical tradition in Paris that continues today. **Charles X's** attempts to return to the past provoked one revolt in 1830, while his successor Louis-Phillipe's misjudgment of the mood for reform in 1848 provoked another **330** >>>, which spread across Europe. In 1871, there was a short-lived and bloody **Paris Commune** based on the one from 1792. In 1968, Paris students almost toppled de Gaulle's government. Today, the French still protest to show their discontent.



PARIS RIOTS 1968

A REVOLUTIONARY TEMPLATE

Vladimir Lenin **377** >>> studied the French Revolution as a **model for change**. During the **Russian Revolution 376–77** >>>, he adopted the need for revolutionary terror along with a citizens' army to defend against invasion and civil war. **Rebuilding society from scratch** found echoes in the Chinese Cultural Revolution **424–25** >>> and in Cambodia's attempt to relocate the towns to the countryside (1975–79).